

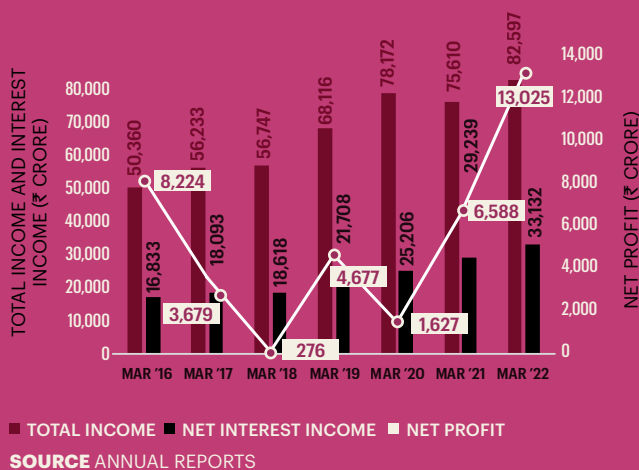
YOU ARE ALWAYS asking us, 'why is the glass half empty?'," a senior Axis Bank team member quizzed MD and CEO Amitabh Chaudhry at a strategy offsite. "What happens when we fill the glass?" asked another member in a lighter vein. Pat came the response: "Well, I will go find a jug." The response is emblematic of the pugnacious approach of the 57-year-old Chaudhry, who was previously credited with turning around the struggling life insurance subsidiary of HDFC. The honcho believes that India's third-largest private bank is capable of doing much more than what it is doing today. And he is moving multiple blocks around to ensure that he and his nine-member senior management team—mostly poached by Chaudhry from other private banks—deliver to that promise. "We are hungry for business; we are like a crouching tiger," says a determined Chaudhry, sitting in

his eighth-floor office at Mumbai's Axis House. "We now have the platform to go and grab every opportunity that comes our way. We are not as aggressive as some others, but we are getting better and better at it."

He sure is. A series of acquisitions, capped by Axis's \$1.64-billion buyout of Citi's consumer business in India this March, underlines this new-found aggression. And now, the crouching tiger is gunning for the position of India's second-largest private bank (by balance sheet size), currently occupied by rival ICICI Bank. The asset gap between the two has shrunk to ₹2.36 lakh crore in FY22, from ₹3.68 lakh crore in FY20. "We need to raise our aspiration level. We are not happy with No. 3. We want to get to No. 2 and No. 1 (in terms of product market share), and the only way we can get to No. 2 (in terms of ranking) is to become No. 1 in some (product market share) cases," argues Chaudhry. An engineer from BITS, Pilani, with management spurs from the prestigious IIM Ahmedabad,

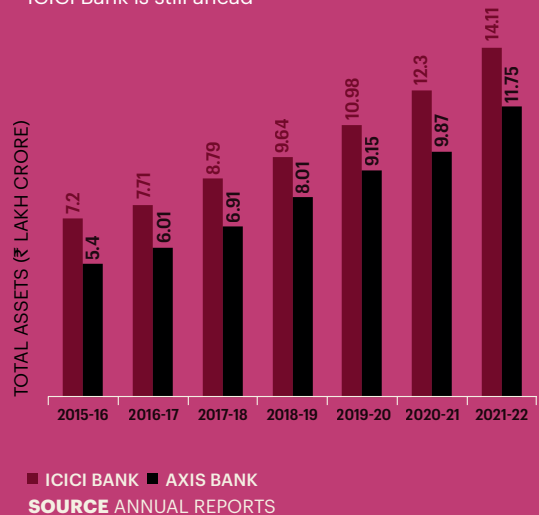
BACK TO GROWTH AND PROFITABILITY

Net profits, in particular, have shot through the roof



PLAYING CATCH-UP

Axis Bank's balance sheet size is fattening, but ICICI Bank is still ahead



AXIS'S BUYING SPREE

The bank is continuing to look at M&A opportunities in general insurance and other segments

NOV 2020

Acquired close to 10 per cent stake in CSC e-Governance Services